

HCCS Branded Merchandise Shop

A Board Suggestion for Discussion

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Purpose: New Revenue Stream Idea

Hope Chinese Charter School (HCCS) is a K-8 dual-language Chinese immersion charter school in Beaverton, Oregon, serving approximately 420 students.

Why This Matters

HCCS's strategic plan sets a clear goal: "Develop new external revenue streams totaling 25% of fundraising target." The school faces a ~\$1M annual funding gap due to Oregon's charter school funding formula (receiving only ~85% of what district schools get per student, with no access to local property tax revenue). At the same time, HCCS has a strong, distinctive brand - a dual-language Chinese immersion school - that isn't being monetized.

A merchandise program turns the school's brand into a revenue stream while building community pride and visibility. It is a low-cost, low-effort way to generate recurring income - something the school currently lacks outside of traditional fundraising events.

What I'm Suggesting

An online merchandise shop - no physical store, no lease, no paid staff. Two complementary approaches:

1. Print-on-demand (zero inventory, zero risk) - products are printed and shipped only when someone orders.
2. Batch ordering around events (higher margins) - order in bulk for the Auction Gala, Chinese New Year, Back to School Night.

Suggested Products

Item	Est. Price	Est. Profit/Unit
Ceramic Mug - school name + Chinese design	\$15-20	\$8-12
T-Shirt - Chinese + English school name	\$20-25	\$10-15
Hoodie - student / parent / alumni designs	\$35-45	\$15-20
Stickers - low cost, high repeat purchase	\$3-5	\$2-3
Tote Bag - canvas with 'Hope CCS' logo	\$10-12	\$5-7
Water Bottle - stainless steel with logo	\$18-22	\$8-10

Design Ideas

- Bilingual school name with traditional Chinese elements (ink wash painting, Chinese knot, dragon motifs)
- A fixed collection of 3-5 designs, rotated seasonally
- Student art contest winners as limited-edition designs

Supplier Recommendations

Print-on-Demand (zero inventory, best for starting)

Supplier	Best For	Notes
Printful (printful.com)	Premium quality mugs, tees, hoodies	US-based production, branded packaging. No upfront cost.
Printify (printify.com)	Best prices, wide catalog	Compare prices across print partners. Cheaper than Printful. No upfront cost.
Spreadshop (spreadshop.com)	Easiest setup	All-in-one store + production. Good for non-technical users.

Supplier	Best For	Notes
Amazon Merch on Demand	Marketplace reach	Amazon handles everything.
		Best for passive sales.

Batch Ordering (higher margins, event sales)

Supplier	Best For	Notes
Custom Ink Fundraising	Schools & teams	Free design help, bulk discounts.
		School fundraising program.
Custom Ink (customink.com)	Individual batch orders	Great for one-off runs.
		No setup fees.

Recommendation:

Start with Printful for ongoing online sales (best quality, no inventory) and Custom Ink Fundraising for event batch orders (higher margins, school-friendly platform).

Business Model

Phase 1 - Print-on-Demand (launch, zero risk)

- Set up a free Printful account
- Link to a simple order page on the HCCS website or use a Google Form
- Platform prints and ships - no school staff time required
- Profit margin: 40-60%

Phase 2 - Batch Ordering at Events (higher margins)

- Order 50-100 pieces for Auction Gala, Chinese New Year, Back to School Night
- Sell at events - instant revenue
- Profit margin: 60-80%

Sales Channels

1. HCCS website - add a Merch link (links to Printful store)
2. School events - Auction Gala, Chinese New Year, Back to School Night, graduation
3. Tiny Dragons parents - PreK families are highly engaged buyers
4. WeChat parent groups - direct link sharing
5. Alumni - graduated families still want school swag

Revenue Estimate

Moderate Scenario

Channel	Est. Units/Year	Avg Profit	Annual Revenue
Event table sales	100	\$10	\$1,000
Online orders	200	\$10	\$2,000
Back-to-school batch	150	\$12	\$1,800
Graduation season	80	\$10	\$800

Channel	Est. Units/Year	Avg Profit	Annual Revenue
Total	~530		~\$5,600

Optimistic scenario (with active promotion): \$8,000 - \$12,000/year.

This won't close the \$1M gap alone - but it's zero-cost recurring income that builds brand visibility and community identity.

Implementation Timeline

Step	Timing	Who
1. Board discussion & approval	Next meeting	Board
2. Finalize designs (align with Brand Standards)	2 weeks after	Volunteer or Fiverr
3. Set up Printful + upload designs	1 week	Admin or parent
4. Order samples for board review	1-2 weeks	Printful samples
5. Launch online store (2-3 products)	Fall 2026	+ WeChat promotion

Budget needed: \$0 for print-on-demand. ~\$50-100 for initial design if no volunteer available.

Strategic Alignment

Strategic Priority	How This Helps
New external revenue streams	Brand new income line item
Community engagement (>=70% volunteer goal)	Parents volunteer for design, distribution
Brand visibility	Merch = walking ads in the community
Family-school partnership	Strengthens identity and belonging
No operational burden	Print-on-demand = zero staff time

Q&A

Q: Does this need budget approval?

A: No. Print-on-demand costs nothing to start. Design is the only potential cost (~\$50-100 if no volunteer is available).

Q: Will this burden staff?

A: Minimal. With print-on-demand, the platform handles everything. Staff time is limited to sharing a link.

Q: What if nothing sells?

A: With print-on-demand, there is no inventory to write off. Zero risk.

Q: Tax/compliance?

A: Revenue falls under 'program services revenue' similar to Tiny Dragons. Confirm with the Finance Committee.

Just a thought - happy to discuss whenever convenient.